CURIOUS SPAROOWS · ENCYCLOPEDIC INDEX · NEEDLE ARTS

KNITTING

How two sticks and a thread turn into a warm sweater

Needles, yarns and machines · stitches and techniques · ways of holding · traditions of the world and India · projects register · history · designers and community · ideas · practical guide

Parts	Sections	Sub-sections	Entries	Register rows
11	27	11	130	40

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How to Use This Booklet

This booklet is a map of knitting: tools and yarns, stitches and techniques, ways of holding, traditions, projects, history, people, ideas and a practical guide.

Every entry has an ID (such as KNT-05.3 for cables). The same ID is the entry's address on curioussparoows.com.

How this booklet is organised

Parts 0 to 10: intro questions, map, tools, stitches and techniques, traditions, projects, history and people, ideas, practical guide, reviews, navigation and sources.

Entries (☐): one or two lines each; tick when learned or made.

Registers: 24 projects and the timeline.

How to explore it

Step 1. Read Part 0.

Step 2. Learn to cast on, knit and purl (Part 3).

Step 3. Make the first projects in order (Part 8).

Step 4. Explore a tradition, from Fair Isle to Indian winter sweaters.

Step 5. Tick ☐ and keep a project log.

Our promise

Knowledge belongs to the people who created it. Patterns are described, never copied; designers are credited. Where something could not be verified, we say so instead of guessing.

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PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: HOW DO TWO STICKS AND A THREAD TURN INTO A WARM SWEATER?

About this Part. The doorway to the Knitting section of the website, in the **Needle Arts** branch with Crochet (CRO), Embroidery (EMB) and Sewing (SEW). One Gateway page, five Leaves and one Recap; each Leaf takes about two minutes.

KNT-00 The Gateway: How do two sticks and a thread turn into a warm sweater?

Web address: /knitting/two-sticks-one-thread/ · **Keywords:** knitting for beginners, what is knitting, history of knitting, knitting stitches, Indian sweater knitting

In millions of Indian homes, winter used to begin with the click of needles: mothers and grandmothers knitting sweaters, caps and socks from balls of wool, often while talking, watching TV or waiting for the pressure cooker to whistle. Knitting turns a single strand into stretchy, warm fabric using only two stitches, knit and purl. From those two moves come Aran cables, Shetland lace, Norwegian star patterns and the T-shirt you are wearing, which was knitted by a machine.

This short course asks one question in five steps: **how does knitting work, and why has it lasted so long?**

By the end you will be able to:

- Say what knitting is and how it differs from crochet and weaving.
- Name the oldest true knitted objects.
- Explain the stories, and the myths, behind fishermen's sweaters.
- Explain how the stocking frame began machine knitting.
- Describe why knitting is often compared to computer code.

KNT-00.01 What is knitting?

> **Short answer:** Knitting makes fabric by pulling new loops through a row of live loops held on needles. Each row hangs from the one below. Because the loops can stretch and slide, knitted fabric is elastic, which is why socks, sweaters, T-shirts and leggings are knitted rather than woven.

Keywords: what is knitting, knit and purl, knitting vs weaving, knitting vs crochet, how knitting works

Two stitches, endless fabric

- **Knit stitch**: a smooth V on the front.
- **Purl stitch**: the back of a knit stitch, a little bump.
- **Stockinette (stocking stitch)**: knit one row, purl the next; smooth on one side.
- **Garter stitch**: knit every row; ridged on both sides.

Its relatives

- **Weaving**: two sets of threads crossing at right angles; firm, not stretchy.
- **Crochet** (CRO): one live loop on a hook.
- **Nalbinding**: an older looping craft with a needle and short lengths; often mistaken for knitting in museums.
- **Machine, loom, arm and finger knitting**: the same loops, made with other tools.

Remember this: Knitting is rows of loops hanging from loops: two stitches, endless fabric.

Next: If knitting is so useful, who knitted first?

KNT-00.02 Who knitted the first sock?

> **Short answer:** The oldest true knitted objects known are fine cotton socks from Egypt, dated to roughly the 11th century CE, knitted in blue and white patterns, some with Arabic inscriptions. Older "Egyptian socks" (3rd to 5th centuries) with a separate big toe were made by nalbinding, not knitting.

Keywords: first knitted sock, history of knitting, Egyptian socks, nalbinding, oldest knitting

From the Islamic world to Europe

Knitting likely spread from the Islamic world into Spain. Cushions knitted in silk were found in a royal tomb at the monastery of Las Huelgas, Burgos (13th century). Paintings of the 14th century, the "Knitting Madonnas", show the Virgin Mary knitting on four needles.

Guilds and stockings

Knitting guilds formed in European cities from the 15th and 16th centuries. Knitted silk stockings became luxury items; England's Queen Elizabeth I loved them.

Why sources are scarce

Wool and cotton rot; most early knitting has disappeared. Historians such as Richard Rutt (*A History of Hand Knitting*, 1987) rely on rare survivals and pictures.

> **Remember this:** Knitting is about a thousand years old in the records, younger than weaving and nalbinding.

Next: Some of the most famous knitting was made for the sea. Why are fishermen's sweaters patterned?

KNT-00.03 Why are fishermen's sweaters patterned?

> **Short answer:** Fishermen's sweaters, the British *gansey* and the Irish *Aran*, were knitted tightly from oiled wool to keep out wind and spray. The patterns (cables, ladders, diamonds) add warmth and strength and show the knitter's skill and local style. The popular story that each family had its own pattern so drowned sailors could be identified is largely a romantic myth.

Keywords: Aran sweater history, gansey, fisherman sweater, Aran myth, cable knitting

Ganseys

Knitted in the round in dark, tightly spun wool, often by fishermen's wives and by "herring girls" who followed the fishing fleets along Britain's coasts. Patterns were local and passed by example.

Aran

The heavy, cream, richly cabled Aran sweater from Ireland's Aran Islands became famous in the 20th century, helped by exports, the Clancy Brothers (who wore them on stage in the 1960s) and marketing. Researchers such as Alice Starmore have traced how recent many "ancient" Aran patterns are.

The myth

A version of the identification story appears in J. M. Synge's play *Riders to the Sea* (1904), where a drowned man is identified by his knitted stockings. It was later attached to Aran patterns, but there is little evidence for "family patterns".

> **Remember this:** The patterns are about warmth and pride; the "drowned sailor" tale is mostly legend.

Next: Knitting went from hands to machines very early. How?

KNT-00.04 How did knitting become a machine?

> **Short answer:** In 1589 William Lee, a clergyman in Calverton, Nottinghamshire, invented the **stocking frame**, a machine with a row of hooked needles that knitted a whole row at once. Queen Elizabeth I refused him a patent,

reportedly worried it would put hand-knitters out of work. The frame later spread and became a pillar of the textile industry.

Keywords: William Lee stocking frame, history of machine knitting, industrial revolution knitting, Luddites, knitting machine

The stocking frame and after

- **1589**: Lee's frame; he moved to France to seek support.
- **1758**: Jedediah Strutt's attachment for ribbed stockings.
- **1811 to 1816**: the **Luddites**, many of them frame-work knitters around Nottingham, broke machines in protest against low wages and cheap work (TEC-21.1).
- **1847**: Matthew Townsend's latch needle, still used today.
- **20th century**: circular knitting machines produce T-shirts, socks and sportswear; home knitting machines (Brother, Passap) became popular.
- **Today**: whole-garment machines (Shima Seiki) knit a complete sweater without seams; India's Tiruppur in Tamil Nadu is a major centre of knitted garments.

Remember this: Knitting was one of the first crafts to become a machine, and its workers were among the first to protest automation.

Next: Knitting patterns look like instructions for a computer. Is knitting a code?

KNT-00.05 Is knitting a kind of computer code?

Short answer: In a way, yes. A knitting pattern is a program: two basic operations (knit and purl, like 1 and 0), loops (repeats), conditions ("if the row is even") and variables (stitch counts). Knitters "execute" the code with their hands. During the World Wars, there were even stories of spies hiding messages in knitting.

Keywords: knitting and coding, knitting binary, knitting algorithm, knitting spies, mathematics of knitting

Patterns as programs

- **Binary**: knit and purl can encode letters, like 0 and 1.
- **Loops**: "repeat from * to the end".
- **Charts**: grids like pixel images or matrices.
- **Errors**: a missed stitch is a bug; "frogging" (ripping out) is debugging.

History and research

- **Jacquard's punched cards** (1804) for looms inspired Babbage and Lovelace's computing ideas (TEC-12.2).
- **Wartime stories**: knitters in occupied Belgium are said to have watched trains and recorded them in stitches; Britain's censors reportedly banned posting knitting patterns abroad in case they hid codes.
- **Mathematics**: knots, topology and hyperbolic surfaces are studied with knitting; MIT and other researchers have built software that writes knitting-machine programs.

Remember this: Every knitter is a programmer with yarn.

Next: The Recap.

KNT-00.06 Recap: loops that hang from loops

- **KNT-00.01**: Knitting uses rows of live loops; two stitches make everything.
- **KNT-00.02**: True knitting appears in Egypt around the 11th century.
- **KNT-00.03**: Fishermen's patterns were for warmth and pride; the drowned-sailor tale is mostly myth.
- **KNT-00.04**: William Lee's stocking frame (1589) began machine knitting.
- **KNT-00.05**: Knitting patterns work like code.

Where to go next: the Master Map (Part 1) and the first projects (Part 9). **Quick quiz:** What is the difference between garter and stockinette? Who invented the stocking frame? What is "frogging"?

PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF KNITTING

KNT-01 The hierarchy: from Forest to Leaf

Before you start — KNT-01. The Forest is "Knitting". Its Trees are tools and materials, stitches and techniques, ways of holding, traditions, projects, and the human side (history, people, ideas, practice). **See also:** CRO-01, EMB-01, SEW-01.

☐ **KNT-01.1 Tools and materials**: needles, yarns, notions and machines (Part 2).
☐ **KNT-01.2 Stitches and techniques**: cast-ons to finishing (Part 3).
☐ **KNT-01.3 Ways of holding**: English, Continental, Portuguese, Combination (Part 3).
☐ **KNT-01.4 Traditions of the world and India** (Part 4).
☐ **KNT-01.5 Projects register** (Part 5).
☐ **KNT-01.6 The human side**: history and people (Part 6), ideas (Part 7), practical guide (Part 8), reviews (Part 9).

PART 2 — TOOLS AND MATERIALS

KNT-02 Needles and machines

Before you start — KNT-02. Needle sizes are best given in **millimetres**. US sizes use numbers (US 8 = 5 mm); old UK and Indian sizes run backwards (UK 6 = 5 mm; Indian shops often still sell needles by old numbers such as 8, 10, 12). Always check the millimetres.

☐ **KNT-02.1 Straight needles**: pairs with a knob at the end; flat pieces; steel, aluminium, plastic, bamboo, wood.

☐ **KNT-02.2 Circular needles**: two tips joined by a cable; for knitting in the round and for heavy flat pieces.

☐ **KNT-02.3 Double-pointed needles (DPNs)**: sets of four or five, for socks, sleeves and hat tops.

☐ **KNT-02.4 Interchangeable needles**: tips that screw onto cables of different lengths.

☐ **KNT-02.5 Cable needles and stitch holders**: to hold stitches aside for cables and pockets.

☐ **KNT-02.6 Knitting looms and boards**: pegs instead of needles; easy for children.

☐ **KNT-02.7 Arm and finger knitting**: chunky loops made on the arms or fingers.

☐ **KNT-02.8 Knitting machines**: hand-operated flatbed machines (Usha, Brother), circular sock machines, industrial whole-garment machines (KNT-00.04).

KNT-03 Yarns and notions

☐ **KNT-03.1 Yarn weights**: the Craft Yarn Council system 0 to 7 (CRO-03.1); in India, wool is often sold as "2-ply", "3-ply" and "4-ply".

☐ **KNT-03.2 Fibres**: wool (merino, Shetland, Indian Deccani and Himalayan wools), cashmere (*pashm* from Changthangi goats of Ladakh), angora, alpaca, mohair, cotton, linen, silk, acrylic and blends; superwash wool for machine washing.

☐ **KNT-03.3 Yarn construction**: plies, twist, woollen versus worsted spinning, hand-dyed and variegated yarns.

☐ **KNT-03.4 Notions**: stitch markers, row counter, tapestry needle, scissors, tape measure, blocking pins and mats, needle gauge, point protectors.

PART 3 — STITCHES, TECHNIQUES AND HOLDING STYLES

KNT-04 Cast-ons, basic stitches and fabrics

☐ **KNT-04.1 Long-tail cast-on**: the all-rounder; stretchy and neat.
☐ **KNT-04.2 Cable cast-on**: firm edge, good for adding stitches mid-work.
☐ **KNT-04.3 Provisional cast-on**: temporary, removed later to knit the other way.
☐ **KNT-04.4 Tubular cast-on**: invisible, elastic edge for ribbing.
☐ **KNT-04.5 Knit and purl**: KNT-00.01.
☐ **KNT-04.6 Stockinette (stocking stitch)**: smooth; curls at the edges.
☐ **KNT-04.7 Garter stitch**: ridged, flat, does not curl; ideal first fabric.
☐ **KNT-04.8 Ribbing**: knit and purl columns (1×1, 2×2); stretchy cuffs and collars.
☐ **KNT-04.9 Seed (moss) stitch**: alternating knit and purl, shifted each row; bumpy texture.

KNT-05 Shaping, patterns and colourwork

☐ **KNT-05.1 Increases**: knit front and back (kfb), make one (M1L, M1R), yarn over (adds a decorative hole).
☐ **KNT-05.2 Decreases**: knit two together (k2tog, leans right), slip-slip-knit (ssk, leans left), central double decreases.
☐ **KNT-05.3 Cables**: crossing groups of stitches using a cable needle; the heart of Aran knitting.
☐ **KNT-05.4 Lace**: patterns of yarn-overs and decreases; Shetland and Estonian lace.
☐ **KNT-05.5 Fair Isle and stranded colourwork**: two colours per row, the unused one carried behind as a "float".
☐ **KNT-05.6 Intarsia**: separate yarns for blocks of colour; no floats.
☐ **KNT-05.7 Double knitting**: two layers at once, reversible colours.
☐ **KNT-05.8 Mosaic (slip-stitch) knitting**: one colour per row, patterns made by slipped stitches (Barbara Walker popularised it).
☐ **KNT-05.9 Brioche**: tucked stitches that make a lofty, reversible rib; two-colour brioche is a modern favourite.
☐ **KNT-05.10 Short rows**: turning before the end of a row to shape heels, shoulders and curves (wrap and turn, German short rows).
☐ **KNT-05.11 Entrelac**: a basketweave of small knitted squares.

KNT-06 Finishing and reading patterns

☐ **KNT-06.1 Bind-offs (cast-offs)**: standard, stretchy (Jeny's surprisingly stretchy bind-off), three-needle bind-off for seams.
☐ **KNT-06.2 Seaming**: mattress stitch, Kitchener stitch (grafting) for invisible sock toes.
☐ **KNT-06.3 Picking up stitches**: for necklines and button bands.
☐ **KNT-06.4 Blocking**: wet, steam or spray blocking to even stitches and open lace.
☐ **KNT-06.5 Gauge (tension)**: stitches and rows per 10 cm; swatch first.
☐ **KNT-06.6 Reading patterns and charts**: abbreviations, repeats, sizes in brackets; charts read right to left on right-side rows; Japanese charts use standard symbols.
☐ **KNT-06.7 Fixing mistakes**: tinking (unknitting stitch by stitch), dropping down a column to fix one stitch, lifelines (a thread through a safe row), frogging.

KNT-07 Ways of holding the yarn

☐ **KNT-07.1 English (throwing)**: yarn in the right hand, wrapped around the needle; common in the UK, USA and much of India.
☐ **KNT-07.2 Continental (picking)**: yarn in the left hand, picked with the needle; often faster; common in Germany and Northern Europe.

☐ **KNT-07.3 Portuguese (around-the-neck)**: yarn tensioned around the neck or a pin and flicked with the thumb; easy purling; also used in Peru, Turkey, Greece and Egypt.

☐ **KNT-07.4 Combination knitting**: Continental knits with "Eastern" purls; Annie Modesitt teaches it.

☐ **KNT-07.5 Knitting belts and sheaths**: Shetland and Fair Isle knitters used a stuffed leather belt to hold one needle, for speed.

PART 4 — TRADITIONS OF THE WORLD AND INDIA

KNT-08 Traditions of the world

☐ **KNT-08.1 Fair Isle (Scotland)**: small, colourful stranded patterns, often only two colours per row; made famous when the Prince of Wales wore a Fair Isle pullover in the 1920s.

☐ **KNT-08.2 Shetland lace**: shawls so fine they could pass through a wedding ring ("wedding ring shawls"); spun and knitted in Unst and Lerwick.

☐ **KNT-08.3 Aran (Ireland)**: cables, honeycomb and diamonds on cream wool (KNT-00.03).

☐ **KNT-08.4 Gansey (British and Channel Islands)**: fishermen's working sweaters; Guernsey and Jersey gave their names to garments.

☐ **KNT-08.5 Norwegian Selbu**: the eight-petal "Selbu rose" mittens, popularised by Marit Gulsetbrua Emstad (1857).

☐ **KNT-08.6 Icelandic* lopapeysa***: round-yoke sweaters of unspun lopi wool, 20th century.

☐ **KNT-08.7 Sanquhar (Scotland)**: two-colour gloves with checked patterns named after local families or places.

☐ **KNT-08.8 Estonian lace**: Haapsalu shawls with *nupps* (bobbles).

☐ **KNT-08.9 Andean* ch'ullu***: colourful hats with ear flaps; in Taquile, Peru, men knit, and the craft is on UNESCO's intangible heritage list (Taquile textile art, 2008).

☐ **KNT-08.10 Turkish and Balkan socks**: richly patterned socks knitted toe-up with symbolic motifs.

☐ **KNT-08.11 Japanese knitting**: precise chart-based pattern books (Nihon Vogue), Hitomi Shida's stitch dictionaries.

☐ **KNT-08.12 Cowichan (Canada)**: sweaters of the Coast Salish peoples, knitted in thick undyed wool with bold motifs.

KNT-09 Knitting in India

☐ **KNT-09.1 Indian winter knitting culture**: from the mid-20th century, hand-knitted sweaters, monkey caps, mufflers and socks made by mothers and grandmothers became a symbol of care; pattern sharing between neighbours and in women's magazines.

☐ **KNT-09.2 Kashmir and the Himalaya**: hand-knitted woollens of Himachal, Uttarakhand, Ladakh and Sikkim; Kullu caps and shawls are woven, not knitted, but sit beside knitted socks and gloves in hill markets; pashmina yarn.

☐ **KNT-09.3 Tibetan refugee knitting**: sweaters and caps sold by Tibetan communities in Indian winter markets.

☐ **KNT-09.4 Indian brands and yarns**: Oswal, Vardhman and other wool brands; the Ludhiana hosiery and knitwear industry; Tiruppur's cotton knitwear cluster (exports worldwide).

☐ **KNT-09.5 Knitting in schools and institutions**: needlework once taught in Indian girls' schools and Home Science; now open to all.

☐ **KNT-09.6 The machine-knitting home business**: Usha and other hand-operated knitting machines that let women run small home businesses.

PART 5 — PROJECTS REGISTER

KNT-10 Projects (register of 24)

Before you start — KNT-10. Level: 1 beginner, 2 easy, 3 intermediate, 4 advanced. Yarn weight by the Craft Yarn Council number. Time is a rough estimate.

Project	Family	Level	Yarn (weight, fibre)	Needles (mm)	Time
Garter-stitch dishcloth	Home	1	4, cotton	4.5	2 hours
Garter-stitch scarf	Accessory	1	5, wool or acrylic	6 to 8	6 to 10 hours
Ribbed muffler	Accessory	1	4, wool	5	10 to 15 hours
Cushion cover	Home	1	5, any	6	8 to 12 hours
Headband or ear warmer	Accessory	2	4, wool	5	2 to 3 hours
Ribbed beanie (in the round)	Accessory	2	4, wool	4.5 to 5 circular	4 to 6 hours
Monkey cap (balaclava)	Accessory (India)	2	3 or 4, wool	4	6 to 10 hours
Baby blanket	Blanket	2	3 or 4, baby wool or cotton	4.5	20 to 30 hours
Simple toy (garter animal)	Toy	2	4, cotton	4	4 to 6 hours
Mittens	Accessory	2	4, wool	4.5 DPNs	5 to 8 hours
Cowl	Accessory	2	5, wool	6 circular	4 to 6 hours
Baby cardigan	Garment	3	3, baby wool	3.5 to 4	15 to 25 hours
Plain socks	Garment	3	1, sock wool with nylon	2.25 to 2.75 DPNs	15 to 25 hours
Child's sweater	Garment	3	3 or 4, wool	4 to 4.5	20 to 35 hours
Adult raglan sweater (top-down)	Garment	3	4, wool	4.5 to 5	35 to 60 hours
Half-sleeve pullover (Indian winter staple)	Garment	3	3, wool	3.5 to 4	25 to 40 hours
Cabled hat	Accessory	3	4, wool	4.5 to 5	6 to 10 hours
Lace scarf	Accessory	3	1 or 2, wool or silk	3.5 to 4	15 to 25 hours
Fair Isle hat	Accessory	3	1 or 2, Shetland wool	3 to 3.5	10 to 15 hours
Brioche cowl	Accessory	3	4, wool	5	8 to 12 hours
Aran sweater	Garment	4	4, cream wool	4.5 to 5	60 to 100 hours
Fair Isle yoke sweater	Garment	4	2, Shetland wool	3 to 3.5	60 to 100 hours
Shetland lace shawl	Lace	4	0, lace-weight wool	3 to 3.5	60 to 120 hours
Entrelac blanket	Blanket	4	4, wool	5	50 to 80 hours

PART 6 — HISTORY, PEOPLE AND COMMUNITY

KNT-11 The history of knitting

Year	Event	Where	Why it matters
3rd to 5th centuries CE	Nalbinding socks with split toes	Egypt	Mistaken for knitting; an ancestor
c. 11th century	Earliest true knitted cotton socks	Egypt	Oldest known knitting
13th century	Knitted silk cushions in the Las Huelgas tombs	Burgos, Spain	Knitting in Europe
c. 1400	"Knitting Madonna" paintings	Germany, Italy	Knitting in art
1527	Knitting guild in Paris (one of the early guilds)	France	Professional knitting
1589	William Lee's stocking frame	England	Machine knitting begins
1600s	Hand-knitted stockings industry in the Yorkshire Dales and elsewhere	England	Knitting as rural income
1811 to 1816	Luddite protests by frame-work knitters	Nottingham	Workers and automation
1847	Latch needle (Matthew Townsend)	England	Faster machines
1914 to 1918, 1939 to 1945	Wartime knitting for soldiers ("Knit for Victory")	Britain, USA, Canada, Australia, India	Civilian war effort
1950s to 1970s	Home knitting peak; Indian winter-sweater culture	Worldwide, India	Knitting at home
1980s	Decline as cheap machine knitwear spreads	Worldwide	Fewer home knitters
2005	First World Wide Knit in Public Day	Worldwide	Knitting as public, social activity
2007	Ravelry opens	USA	Online knitting community
2020s	Pandemic knitting boom; celebrity knitters	Worldwide	Young knitters return

KNT-12 Designers, teachers and community

☐ **KNT-12.1 Elizabeth Zimmermann (1910 to 1999)**: *Knitting Without Tears* (1971), *Knitter's Almanac*; the Baby Surprise Jacket; "knit on, with confidence and hope, through all crises".

☐ **KNT-12.2 Kaffe Fassett (born 1937)**: designer of bold colour knitting and patchwork; first living textile artist given a solo show at the V&A (1988).

☐ **KNT-12.3 Barbara G. Walker**: the *Treasury of Knitting Patterns* series (from 1968), the stitch dictionaries every designer uses.

☐ **KNT-12.4 Alice Starmore**: Fair Isle and Aran research and design.

☐ **KNT-12.5 Modern designers**: Kate Davies, Stephen West, Andrea Mowry, Norah Gaughan, Jared Flood (Brooklyn Tweed), Hitomi Shida, Arne & Carlos.

☐ **KNT-12.6 Knitters in public life**: Olympic diver Tom Daley (knitting in the stands at Tokyo 2020); the Pussyhat Project (2017).

☐ **KNT-12.7 Indian knitters**: generations of home knitters, whose patterns lived in notebooks; Indian knitting teachers and designers online who credit patterns.

☐ **KNT-12.8 Guilds and events**: The Knitting and Crochet Guild (UK, 1978), The Knitting Guild Association (USA), Edinburgh Yarn Festival, Shetland Wool Week (2010), Rhinebeck Sheep and Wool Festival, World Wide Knit in Public Day (second Saturday in June; begun 2005).

☐ **KNT-12.9 Records**: speed-knitting and largest-knit records are listed by Guinness World Records; check for current holders.

PART 7 — IDEAS: PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY

KNT-13 Knitting and the mind

☐ **KNT-13.1 Mental health**: a survey of 3,545 knitters (Riley, Corkhill and Morris, *British Journal of Occupational Therapy*, 2013) found that most felt calmer and happier after knitting; Betsan Corkhill's "Stitchlinks" work on therapeutic knitting.

☐ **KNT-13.2 Knitting and the ageing brain**: a Mayo Clinic study (Geda and colleagues, 2011) linked crafting in later life with lower odds of mild cognitive impairment; association, not proof.

☐ **KNT-13.3 Knitting as code**: KNT-00.05; patterns, binary and algorithms.

KNT-14 Knitting and society

☐ **KNT-14.1 Craftivism**: craft as gentle activism; Betsy Greer coined the word (2003); yarn bombing; the Pussyhat Project.

☐ **KNT-14.2 Women's history and unpaid work**: knitting for families and soldiers, rarely counted as work; Rozsika Parker's ideas (CRO-12.1).

☐ **KNT-14.3 Sustainability**: long-lasting, repairable garments; mending and darning; natural and recycled fibres; mulesing-free and responsibly sourced wool.

☐ **KNT-14.4 Knitting and men**: men knitted professionally in guilds, at sea and in the Andes; knitting is for everyone.

PART 8 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE

KNT-15 First projects, fixing, care and buying

☐ **KNT-15.1 The first projects in order**: dishcloth, garter scarf, ribbed muffler, beanie in the round, mittens, baby cardigan, socks, a first sweater.

☐ **KNT-15.2 Fixing common mistakes**: dropped stitches (crochet hook up the ladder), extra stitches (count each row), twisted stitches, holes from accidental yarn-overs, uneven tension (practise and block).

☐ **KNT-15.3 Care**: hand-wash wool in cool water with wool wash; never wring; dry flat in shade; fold, don't hang; store with neem or cedar against moths; de-pill with a sweater comb.

☐ **KNT-15.4 Buying yarn ethically**: read fibre content; ask about animal welfare (mulesing), fair wages and dyes; buy from local spinners and cooperatives; reuse yarn by unravelling old sweaters.

☐ **KNT-15.5 Selling handmade**: price for time and materials; respect pattern licences; label fibres honestly.

☐ **KNT-15.6 Safety and comfort**: breaks for hands and wrists; good light; keep needles away from small children.

PART 9 — REVIEWS AND VOICES

KNT-16 Critics' Corner, the experts said I say, and My Review Desk

☐ **KNT-16.1 Books**: Richard Rutt, *A History of Hand Knitting* (1987); Zimmermann, *Knitting Without Tears* (1971); Barbara Walker's *Treasuries*; Clara Parkes, *The Knitter's Book of Yarn* (2007); Hitomi Shida's stitch books.

☐ **KNT-16.2 Media**: *Vogue Knitting*, *Interweave Knits*, *The Knitter*, *Pom Pom Quarterly*; Ravelry pattern reviews; YouTube teachers who show both English and Continental styles.

☐ **KNT-16.3 Review template**: the pattern, yarn or book in two lines (dated price); what others said (3 to 5 named views, in my words); what I say (clarity, errors, yarn behaviour, fit, time); who made it (for bought knitwear); my rating on a clear five-point scale; tags and try-next links.

PART 10 — NAVIGATION, SOURCES AND NOTES

KNT-17 Tag dictionary and site map

☐ **KNT-17.1 Tags**: #knitting #needles #yarn #wool #cotton; technique tags (#caston #cables #lace #fairisle #intarsia #brioche #shortrows); tradition tags (#aran #gansey #shetland #selbu #lopapeysa #chullu #india); project tags (#scarf #hat #socks #sweater #shawl #blanket #toy); level and theme tags (#beginner #history #mentalhealth #craftivism #sustainability).

☐ **KNT-17.2 Cross-links**: Crochet (CRO), Embroidery (EMB), Sewing (SEW); Technology (textile machines: TEC-07); Sports (Tom Daley); the Curriculum Index (Home Science, Mathematics and coding).

☐ **KNT-17.3 Web addresses**: /knitting/ (home, Gateway), /knitting/two-sticks-one-thread/<leaf>/ , /knitting/tools/<tool>/ , /knitting/yarn/<fibre>/ , /knitting/stitches/<stitch>/ , /knitting/techniques/<technique>/ , /knitting/holding/<style>/ , /knitting/traditions/<tradition>/ , /knitting/projects/<project>/ , /knitting/history/<era>/ , /knitting/people/<name>/ , /knitting/ideas/<topic>/ , /knitting/guide/<topic>/ , /knitting/reviews/<item>/ .

☐ **KNT-17.4 Search phrases to own**: "knitting for beginners", "how to cast on", "knitting needle size chart mm US UK", "how to knit a sweater for beginners", "Aran sweater history", "how to fix a dropped stitch", with Hindi lines ("sweater bunna kaise sikhe", "sui ka number mm mein", "bunai ke design").

KNT-S Sources and credits

☐ **Bodies and museums**: Craft Yarn Council; The Knitting and Crochet Guild (UK); Victoria and Albert Museum; Shetland Museum and Archives; Aran Islands heritage centres; UNESCO (Taquile textile art).

☐ **Books and research**: Richard Rutt (1987); Alice Starmore, *Aran Knitting* (1997); Barbara G. Walker; Riley, Corkhill and Morris (2013); Geda and colleagues, *Journal of Neuropsychiatry and Clinical Neurosciences* (2011); Betsy Greer, *Craftivism* (2014).

KNT-E Editor's notes

1. **Nalbinding versus knitting**: the 3rd- to 5th-century Egyptian socks are corrected to nalbinding.
2. **The Aran "drowned sailor" story** is marked as largely myth.
3. **The stocking frame's patent refusal** is reported with "reportedly".
4. **Indian needle numbers** are explained with millimetre conversions.
5. **Added beyond the brief**: Cowichan sweaters, Tiruppur and Ludhiana, the Luddites, craftivism, Kitchener stitch, ethical wool, and knitting research on ageing.

KNT-T My Knitting Tracker

Tick ☐ as you learn each stitch and finish each project. Keep a project log: date, project, pattern and designer, yarn, needles, hours, what I learned, who I gave it to.

Progress tracker

Part	Sections	Explored ☐	Started	Finished
PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: HOW DO TWO STICKS AND A THREAD TURN INTO A WARM SWEATER?	7			
PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF KNITTING	1			
PART 2 — TOOLS AND MATERIALS	2			
PART 3 — STITCHES, TECHNIQUES AND	4			

HOLDING STYLES				
PART 4 — TRADITIONS OF THE WORLD AND INDIA	2			
PART 5 — PROJECTS REGISTER	1			
PART 6 — HISTORY, PEOPLE AND COMMUNITY	2			
PART 7 — IDEAS: PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY	2			
PART 8 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE	1			
PART 9 — REVIEWS AND VOICES	1			
PART 10 — NAVIGATION, SOURCES AND NOTES	4			